

BUYER RESOURCES

Waterfront Inspection Checklist

What to walk through on a Minnesota lake home — beyond what a standard inspection catches.

MinnesotaLakeHomesForSale.com · Updated May 2026

Why this exists

A standard home inspection covers roof, structure, and mechanicals. It will not catch a failing septic mound, a shoreline that's sliding into the lake, ice-damaged sheathing on the lakeside wall, or a dock that won't pass a township ordinance. This checklist covers the lake-specific items. Use it alongside, not instead of, your whole-home inspection.

How to use it

Print this sheet. Hand a copy to your inspector before they walk the property. Walk through with them, item by item. Anything that's flagged becomes a line item in your inspection-response negotiation — get a written quote before negotiating dollars.

Septic system

Mound, conventional, or holding-tank systems are common on Minnesota lakeshore. Most counties require a Certificate of Compliance at sale or transfer.

- Type identified (mound / trench / chamber / holding tank / shared)
- Most recent compliance certificate on file with county (date and result noted)
- Tank pumped within last 3 years; receipt available
- Drainfield free of standing water, lush green stripes, or sewage odor
- Setback from well meets county requirement (typically 50 ft)
- Setback from ordinary high-water mark meets shoreland rule (typically 50–75 ft)
- Tank is accessible — riser to grade, lid intact
- Holding-tank service contract in place (if applicable)

Well & water quality

- Well type identified (drilled, sandpoint, shared)
- Well log on file (depth, casing, year drilled)
- Water tested for total coliform, E. coli, nitrates within last 12 months
- Iron and manganese tested; treatment system noted if present
- Well head 12+ inches above grade and capped
- Pressure tank cycles correctly; no waterlogged tank
- Filtration / softener system documented (age, service contract)

- Pitless adapter present on drilled well; no exposed pipe

Shoreline & water frontage

- Frontage measured and matches the listing
- Shoreline material identified (natural, riprap, retaining wall, sandblanket)
- Erosion checked — bare soil, undercutting, exposed roots, fallen trees
- Riprap or wall in good condition; no displaced rocks or leaning
- Sandblanket permit on file (if a sand beach is present — required in MN)
- Shoreland buffer compliance (vegetated 25–50 ft strip required in many counties)
- Ice-heave damage noted (lakeside foundation, sheds, fire pits, retaining walls)
- Ordinary High-Water Mark (OHWM) located on survey

Dock, lift & water access

- Dock type (permanent, sectional, roll-in, floating)
- Permit on file (some lakes require permanent-dock permits)
- Bottom condition (sand, muck, weed, rock) and depth at end of dock
- Boat lift age and condition; canopy present and intact
- Lift wheels or rails for in/out; storage location identified
- Watercraft included in sale documented in writing
- Shared-access easements identified and in writing
- Mooring whip / posts inspected for rot or damage

Ice, weather & seasonal exposure

Lake-facing walls and roofs see ten times the freeze-thaw cycles of a year-round home. Look for the cumulative damage.

- Lakeside wall sheathing free of staining, soft spots, separation
- Roof flashing intact on dormers, valleys, lakeside eaves
- Frost-heave damage to lakeside steps, decks, foundation
- Storm windows and doors operate; lake-side glazing not delaminated
- Gutters intact and pitched correctly (lake-side often the worst)
- Heat tape or de-icing system on lake-facing eaves (if present) functions

Year-round vs. seasonal access

- Road access classification (county / township year-round, township seasonal, private)
- Snow-plow arrangement documented
- Driveway grade safe for fuel, septic-pump, and emergency vehicles
- Bridge weight limits noted (some township roads have 5-ton limits)
- Mail / package delivery service confirmed
- Utility lines mapped (electric, propane, internet, water if municipal)

Heat plant & freeze risk

- Heat source identified (forced-air LP, in-floor, baseboard, fireplace primary)
- BTU sized for actual square footage and insulation level
- Pipes routed through unconditioned crawl space identified; heat tape in place
- Drain-down procedure documented if cabin is winterized
- Smart-thermostat / freeze alarm in place; cellular backup present
- Propane tank ownership (owned, leased) and service contract noted

Outbuildings, structures & accessories

- Detached garage / pole barn / bunkhouse inspected separately
- Sauna, fish house, ice house — propane, electrical, ventilation
- Fire ring / fire pit compliance with county ordinance
- Sheds and storage structures permitted (or grandfathered with documentation)
- Generator / standby power (size, fuel, transfer switch type)

Documents to collect during inspection

- Septic Certificate of Compliance
- Well log and current water-quality test results
- Property survey showing OHWM and easements
- Sandblanket permit (if present)
- Dock permit (if required by lake or township)
- Lake-association documents (dues, covenants, shared-access rules)

- Township short-term-rental rules (if you intend to rent)
- Past two years of property-tax statements

Notes & follow-up

Use the lines below to capture findings during the walk-through. Get written quotes before negotiating any items.

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Companion resources

Lake Region Comparison Guide · First-Time Lake Buyer Roadmap · Property Tax + Lakeshore Tax Estimator · All available at MinnesotaLakeHomesForSale.com/resources.

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